

THE 'DOUBLE 100' DREAM

- BRS has set a target to win 100 of the 119 seats in Telangana
- The more ambitious goal is to corner 100 Lok Sabha seats next year, even as insiders say the party will enter the fray only in Maharashtra, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh besides Telangana. Together, they account for 118 parliamentary seats
- While the BRS has ruled out a pre-poll alliance, KCR plans to set out on a pan-India tour in June
- To test the water, BRS will contest local body polls in Maharashtra this year. KCR has been holding rallies in the state since February
- In Karnataka, it has identified 40 assembly segments spread over 12 districts that have a significant Telugu-speaking population. For now, it is drumming up support for the JD(S)
- In Andhra, BRS is opposing the privatisation of Vizag Steel Plant, cashing in on an emotive issue
- Farmers remain at the core of KCR's grand plans, and he is showcasing his pro-agriculture and development schemes in a bid to make inroads into other states
- Back home, he is working overtime to implement newly announced populist schemes and speed up the old ones
- MLAs have been tasked with forming teams to reach out to the electorate for sharing information on government schemes
- For a reality check, KCR is also toying with the idea to hold local body polls on 6,000-odd vacant seats

Velugu programme, to test the eyesight of all adults to prevent avoidable blindness, has already covered 10 million people in the first 50 days. Harish Rao lists other schemes that are bringing in "transformative changes": 24-hour free power supply to farmers, Mission Kakatiya (restoration of irrigation tanks and lakes), Mission Bhagiratha (safe drinking water supply to villages) and Harithaharam (afforestation).

But a few flagship programmes have come into question for poor implementation. For instance, the 2BHK housing scheme launched for the poor in 2015. While the government received 1 million applications, it approved 292,000 and floated tenders to construct just 228,000 houses. Records show 160,000 tenements were readied, of which fewer than 60,000 have been allotted. On April 17, vexed with the inordinate delay in the allotment of houses ready since 2018, some applicants in Jangaon broke open the locks and occupied them.

To placate the aggrieved, KCR in March announced a Rs 3 lakh one-time grant to 400,000 beneficiaries who have a plot to build homes under the Gruha Lakshmi scheme. A "green channel" is being created for swift disbursal of funds, as party workers fear any delay could backfire when the state goes to the polls later this year. Equally challenging is the promise to regularise both unlawful squatting on government land and distribution of 'podu' forest land among tribals. Extending the Dalit Bandhu scheme and distributing the 'podu' land pattas (title rights) were the key files KCR signed on entering his office at the new state secretariat on April 30. Critics see his appeasement initiatives for select sections as signs of desperation in an election year. "The BRS government will collapse under its own weight of broken promises," says Telangana Congress chief A. Revanth Reddy. "The failure of schemes like the 2BHK housing, jobs to every household and uninterrupted power supply for farming will ensure its defeat."

GOVT SCHEMES SUCH AS 2BHK HOUSING FOR THE POOR HAVE COME INTO QUESTION DUE TO THEIR POOR IMPLEMENTATION

EAR TO THE GROUND

For a reality check, KCR is toying with the idea to conduct polls on 6,000-odd local body seats lying vacant for nearly three years. Though the TRS won 95 per cent of the seats in 2019, the move looks risky, given the BJP's aggressive politicking and improving electoral prospects besides the challenge posed by the Congress. Rebel trouble with growing infighting in the BRS is another cause of worry. But political analysts feel, as of now, it is "advantage BRS" as there is no apparent anti-KCR wave in the state. "The BRS is the frontrunner with its formidable resources and leadership," says Harathi Vageeshan, a political scientist at the NALSAR University, Hyderabad. "It will enter both the assembly and Lok Sabha elections, highlighting its performance."

At the party plenary on April 27—the BRS Foundation Day and the first after the name change—KCR said that legislators facing allegations of corruption, especially in the implementation of flagship welfare schemes, are unlikely to be fielded again. They could even face suspension from the party. He plans to hold one-on-one meetings with laggard MLAs after the elections in Karnataka. In effect, the BRS is to bank on newbies to counter anti-incumbency in more than 30 seats. Meanwhile, the customary show of strength usually held the same day has been put off to October 10 in Warangal. The party has attributed it to the ongoing harvesting of the rabi crop. Though, October will be the right time for KCR to gauge if the seeds of the grand ambition that he has planted stand a chance to yield the desired dividends. ■